

Trying to Think with Emily Dickinson

A reading of Jed Deppman (2005),
The Emily Dickinson Journal 14.1: 84-103

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Two Epigraphs: The Central Tension

“Why not an ‘eleventh hour’ in the life of the mind as well as such an one in the life of the soul...”

-- Dickinson to Austin, 1851 (L44)

“the more consciousness, the more intense the despair.”

-- Kierkegaard, *Sickness unto Death*

- Dickinson: thinking is an existential drama, equal to the soul's.
- Kierkegaard: deeper consciousness means deeper despair.
- The paper lives in the gap between these two claims.

The Critical Debate

The received view (what Deppman opposes):

- Dickinson privileges emotional and physical response over clarity of thought.
- Peterson: her impassioned poems become “a series of ecstatic assertions, an abandonment to excess verging on mental unbalance” (500).

Deppman’s entry point:

- Her “famous opacity” has led readers to treat affect as primary.
- He will “argue the opposite case.”

The Thesis

“...I will argue the opposite case and portray her not as a mystic but as a serious thinker.” (p. 85)

- Not “ecstatic assertions” but “careful sequences of ideas and images.”
- Not “abandonment to excess” but “thoughtful production of, and reaction to, extreme states of being.”
- Goal: how Dickinson conceived the activity of thinking, and “how writing poetry helped her think.”

Evidence 1: Word Statistics

Rosenbaum Concordance (1955 Johnson edition):

- Feeling-words: feel 39, felt 35, feels 16, feeling 8; body 10, bodies 1.
- Thinking-words: thought 69, think 43, know 230, knew 80; mind 79, brain 26.
- “know” is the 4th most common verb overall (after be, be able, have).
- Deppman: “much more about thought than feeling” (p. 86).
- But his own caveat: the statistics are “partial and decontextualized” (p. 86).

Evidence 2: The Many Faces of Thought

Thought is a “consistent as well as kaleidoscopic” topic (p. 85):

- Celebratory: “Best Things dwell out of Sight / ... Our Thought” (Fr1012)
- Cautionary: “If wrecked upon the Shoal of Thought...” (Fr1503)
- Analytic: “The Brain - is wider than the Sky -” (Fr598)
- Wild: “The Brain, within it’s Groove / Runs evenly ... But let a Splinter swerve -” (Fr563)
- Sufficient for happiness: “The revery alone will do, / If bees are few” (Fr1779)

Framework 1: Postmodern Dickinson

- Wolff: “artist of the age of transition” - freeing language “from the tyranny of His definitions” (429).
- Porter: the mind “explosive with signifying power but disinherited from transcendent knowledge” (7).
- Lyotard: postmodernism is “incredulity toward metanarratives.”
- Derrida: Dickinson as “bricoleuse,” mixing religious, literary, and scientific vocabularies.
- Root condition: the tension between Lockean empiricism (her schoolbooks) and Kantian / Transcendentalist apprehension of the supersensible (p. 86).

Framework 2: The Kantian Sublime

The engine of the whole paper:

- 1. Reason conceives something conceivable but unpresentable (infinity, death).
- 2. Reason demands an adequate image.
- 3. Imagination tries and fails.
- 4. The mind repeats the try; from this the sublime emerges.
- Lyotard: “invent allusions to the conceivable which cannot be presented” (Postmodern 81).
- Key concession: Dickinson “did not read Kant” (p. 87) - a shared attitude, not influence.

The Origin of “Trying” (L10, 1846)

At age fifteen, Dickinson tries to think her own death:

“I cannot imagine with the farthest stretch of my imagination my own death scene... I cannot realize that the grave will be my last home...”

- The refrain: “I cannot imagine ... I cannot realize ... nor can I realize ...”
- The mind “stretches, fails, realizes it fails, regroups, rewords, and reaches its limit again” (p. 88).
- Core formula: “she cannot think death or Eternity ... but she cannot not think them either.”

Evidence 3: The Higginson Letters

Writing understood as thought:

- 1862 (L260): “Are you too deeply occupied to say if my Verse is alive?”
- The bind (L260): “The Mind is so near itself - it cannot see, distinctly - and I have none to ask -.”
- Writing as therapy (L261): “I had a terror ... and so I sing, as the Boy does by the Burying Ground - because I am afraid.”
- Thought over language (L261): “While my thought is undressed ... but when I put them in the Gown - they look alike, and numb.”
- To the end (L1042): “bereft of Book and Thought, by the doctor’s reproof.”

Defining the “Try-to-Think” Poem

- Purpose: to force the mind to satisfy reason’s unsatisfiable demand for a complete image.
- “the try is usually serious, the goal explicitly stated, ... emphasis squarely on the willful movements of thought.”
- They are “precisely sequenced, if difficult, thought experiments” - readers repeat the steps.

Examples: “Of Death I try to think like this” (Fr1588); “The nearest Dream recedes” (Fr304B); “I think To Live - may be a Bliss” (Fr757).

Close Reading 1: Fr570 and the Dilemma

“I tried to think a lonelier Thing / Than any I had seen - / Some Polar Expiation - An Omen in the Bone / Of Death’s tremendous nearness - ... I plucked at our Partition - ... I almost strove to clasp his Hand, / Such Luxury - it grew - / That as Myself - could pity Him - / Perhaps he - pitied me -”

The interpretive dilemma (p. 94):

- Proactive? - a “virtuoso attempt to conceptualize an extreme human possibility.”
- Reactive? - an attempt “to knead it, battle it, alter it, realize it, or just survive it through thought.”
- Deppman chooses: reactive.

Close Reading 2: Tracking the Steps

- 1. Naming the “Thing” as two quiddities:
 - “Some Polar Expiation” - expiation plus polar expedition: radical exile from self, culture, nature.
 - “An Omen in the Bone / Of Death’s tremendous nearness” - anticipatory; near in time and space.
- 2. Borrowing a “Duplicate” - a spirit “Of Heavenly Love - forgot -”: the “smallest possible unit of imagined community.”
- 3. “Within the Clutch of Thought” - undecidable: reachable by thought, or made only of thought (fabricated)?
- 4. “our Partition” - the possessive forms “a we”: bridge and barrier between living self and dead twin.

Close Reading 3: The Paradoxical Close

“I almost strove to clasp his Hand, / Such Luxury - it grew - / That as Myself - could pity Him - / Perhaps he - pitied me -”

- Two God-forsaken souls in “Opposing Cells” - “a chilling scene reminiscent of Beckett’s *Godot*.”
- Deppman hears an elided phrase: “Such Luxury - it grew [- to think].”
- So consolation comes from the experimental force of thought itself.
- But: “a fragile state and a momentary victory” - how long can it console?

Critical Assessment: Strengths

- Methodological rigor - grounds a large claim in concordance data (p. 86), not impression. A falsifiable move.
- Genuine integration - the letters (L10, L260, L261) function as evidence of a poetics, not decorative biography.
- A generative concept - the “try-to-think poem” names a real, repeatable pattern, applicable beyond his sample.
- Reframes opacity as method - difficulty is the trace of a mind at work, not failure or excess.

Critical Assessment: My Position

Claim: the thesis is self-undermining - and that is its most interesting result.

- Deppman picks thought over feeling. Yet his own reading of Fr570 runs on affect: “desperate,” “chilling,” “sickening loneliness,” writing as “thought’s psychotherapeutic response to troubling emotion” (p. 90).
- If the “try” matters only because the loneliness is unbearable, then thought and feeling are inseparable - the binary collapses.
- So the real achievement is the opposite of the stated one: thinking is an emotional act.
- Further bait: “Kant without Kant” (p. 87); the circularity of the genre; Muldoon’s Civil War reading (note 18).

Conclusion and Discussion Questions

- Deppman: these are poems in which she “tried to help or save herself by representing her own efforts to help or save herself” (p. 100).
- To join the poem is to risk “experiencing a loneliness we cannot sound.”
- Return to Kierkegaard: thought is both consolation and risk.

Discussion questions:

- 1. Does the thought/feeling binary survive Deppman’s own close reading?
- 2. Is the Kantian sublime valid for a poet who never read Kant?
- 3. Is “try-to-think” a discovered genre or a critic’s construct?
- 4. Whose reading of Fr570 convinces you - Deppman’s or Muldoon’s?